



IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Drama

DIRECTOR

Elia Kazan

WRITERS

**Tennessee Williams,
Oscar Saul (screenplay);
Tennessee Williams (play)**

STARS

**Marlon Brando, Vivien
Leigh, Kim Hunter,
Karl Malden**

BEFORE

1950 Tennessee Williams adapts his own play, *The Glass Menagerie*, for the screen. It is a thematic companion piece to *A Streetcar Named Desire*.

AFTER

1954 Elia Kazan is reunited with Marlon Brando to make *On the Waterfront*.

1958 Elizabeth Taylor and Paul Newman star in *Cat on a Hot Tin Roof*, another blistering adaptation of a Williams play.

I HAVE ALWAYS RELIED ON THE KINDNESS OF STRANGERS

A STREETCAR NAMED DESIRE / 1951

There isn't much kindness on display in *A Streetcar Named Desire*, which tells the story of Blanche Dubois (Vivien Leigh), a woman whose past catches up with her one stifling summer's evening in New Orleans. "Deliberate cruelty," she says, "is the one unforgivable thing."

When she comes to stay with her younger sister Stella (Kim Hunter), Blanche thinks she is running away from her former life as a scandal-hounded teacher. In reality, she is running toward a cataclysm of destruction and cruelty in the hulking shape of Stella's husband, Stanley Kowalski (Marlon Brando). Blanche has a horror of the naked truth, which she has a habit of disguising with illusions and wily fantasies: "I don't tell the truth. I tell what ought to be the truth!" The moment Blanche arrives at Stella's apartment, Stanley scents her fear, and a game of cat and mouse ensues. He is a predator who resents his sister-in-law's snooty put-downs, and the game ends with a violent sexual



One of only two movies in history to win three Academy Awards for acting, *A Streetcar Named Desire* made a household name out of its star, the now legendary Marlon Brando.

attack. This taut adaptation of Tennessee Williams's play sparked outrage when its director, Elia Kazan, first screened it for Warner Bros., and he was forced to cut five minutes from his movie before the studio's executives would release it.

Controversial themes

These small but crucial edits papered over the more sordid aspects of the story—Blanche's "nymphomania," her late husband's secret homosexuality, Stella's lust for Stanley, and the climactic rape—inadvertently mirroring the self-